KHABY LAME

In 2022, a Senegalese/Italian TikTok star, Khaby Lame, became the most viewed individual on TikTok, overtaking Charli D'Amelio. Lame's videos are pure comedy. Relying on facial expressions, hand gestures, filters and text, his videos are carefully crafted snippets of comedy and satire of the world of social media itself. Despite creating hours of content and amassing billions of views on TikTok, he has rarely spoken a word on his feed. Lame speaks Italian and English but the decision not to talk in his videos means he is universally understood around the world.

Unlike D'Amelio, who has influenced an entire generation to copy and reproduce dance trends, Lame turns the tables and makes fun of TikTok and its popular 'life hacks' trends offering simple solutions. In a world dominated by carefully crafted lighting, trends and 'spontaneity', Lame's appeal is his authenticity.



FIGURE 6.40 Khaby Lame became the most viewed individual on TikTok in 2022.

INFLUENCE OF INFLUENCERS ON TIKTOK

TikTok draws users in by making it simple to belong. The app provides the tools to 'respond' and make videos appear just like those of the most popular stars and create a sense of belonging. D'Amelio is credited with popularising a range of dance trends (although some of them were not hers) and influencing a generation of users to believe that they can rise to fame and fortune in the same manner as D'Amelio and Lame. However, a central element of any influencer's career is paid sponsorship and being used as a vehicle to sell products to them.

On TikTok, like many other social media apps, loose laws and guidelines are in place to tell users when the post is 'sponsored' or, in simple terms, an ad. Charli D'Amelio has more than 140 million followers, and she also has a sponsorship deal with a tea brand called 'Muse'. In one recent **Q&A post**, she was asked, 'What's so special about the muse drink?' and responded 'This one's pretty simple. They're really good, and I really like them. And they have a lot of different flavours and a lot of health benefits'. Nowhere in the post did she tag that it was sponsored content and, in most cases, there are very few consequences for these breaches of TikTok's paid advertising guidelines.[17]

Q&A post a social media post made by an influencer or celebrity that asks followers to post questions with the intention of answering them directly

Advertising, sponsored content and product placement are not new concepts. But their links with some of the world's most popular stars is cause for concern when TikTok's largest audience are younger and more impressionable users. In October 2022, the Australian Therapeutic Goods Administration (TGA) issued a warning against a 'nasal tanning' spray that was heavily promoted by a range of Australian TikTok influencers. Nicknamed the 'Barbie Drug', the nasal spray was sold by influencers as a quick and easy way to get a tan, ready for summer. The TGA warned the drugs can cause kidney failure, shortness of breath, chest pain, abdominal cramping and dizziness.[18] By October 2022, these videos had been watched millions of times.

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